Lawbreaking hunters spread costly feral plague across WA

SUELLEN JERRARD

Gun-happy West Australians are adding to the State's feral animal problem by illegally releasing deer and pigs into the wild for recreational hunting.

Experts are demanding tougher penalties to stop the practice, which they say WA can ill afford given its already huge feral animal challenges.

Feral animals — ranging from rabbits to camels — cover the State, leaving a trail of damage worth hundreds of millions of dollars and demanding management programs costing tens of millions more.

While efforts to tackle their environmental, economic and social impact date back to not long after many arrived with the First Fleet, in most cases it is a losing battle.

Department of Environment and Conservation acting assistant director Peter Mawson said recreational hunters were ensuring the fight against feral pigs was being lost in the South-West.

"Feral pigs are being translocated and released illegally by recreational hunters on a pretty massive scale," he said. "We've got proof using DNA technology that feral pigs are being transported up to 400km."

Dr Mawson said it was the same with deer, which had been illegally released from failing commercial farms. The current $200 fine was grossly inadequate.

"The fines haven't been changed since the 1970s or 80s and don't reflect current community expectations and don't reflect the costs of rectifying those problems," he said.

Dr Mawson said it was hoped WA's proposed Biosecurity and Agriculture Management Act, now before Parliament, would lead to not only tougher penalties but more resources and a more co-ordinated approach to feral animal control.

His department was mounting its third consecutive case for a big increase in spending on the problem. The growing threat from cane toads and starlings and a slump in landholder efforts expected to flow from the drought were expected to make the argument more compelling.

"The costs, however large they might appear to some people, if we get going now will be extremely modest in comparison to the cost of lost production, reduced public amenity and lost biodiversity value," Dr Mawson said.

Experts say detailing those costs is as difficult as counting every feral animal roaming the massive continent. As well as being a major agricultural pest, feral animals cause land degradation, threaten the survival of native flora and fauna and are a disease risk.

The only estimate thrashed out so far, by the former Co-operative Research Centre for Pest Animal Control, put the cost to Australia at $720 million annually. But that excluded most environmental and social impacts.

A Department of Agriculture study last year found foxes had the biggest impact in the State's agricultural region. In the pastoral region, wild dogs had the highest economic and social effect while cats had the greatest environmental impact.

Feral pig and cat populations had increased the most in the agricultural region in the past five years, while feral dogs were on the rise in the pastoral region.

Dr Mawson said there was also the growing problem of feral cattle in the Kimberley. Goat numbers in the rangelands were thought to be doubling every 8-10 years and half of the 600,000 feral camels across central Australia were in WA.

But it is not all bad news. The myxoma virus and calicivirus have dramatically reduced the rabbit population, more than 550,000 donkeys have been removed from the Kimberley and WA's long-running fox-baiting project Western Shield is the most successful campaign yet in aiding the recovery of native species.

While the management of well-established pests continues, WA's focus is largely on keeping new pests out of the State. More than $6 million is being spent this year trying to keep cane toads at bay in the north and $3.15 million to keep starlings at bay in the south-east.

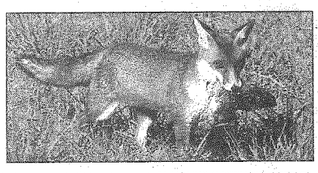
"Cost benefit studies show that a dollar spent on eradication of a new pest returns about $25, whereas a dollar spent on the management of an established pest only returns about $2," Department of Agriculture and Food invasive species director Damien Collopy said.

Invasive Animal Co-operative Research Centre chief executive Tony Peacock agreed the focus was justified but said established pests could not be ignored.

To that end, a national database of feral animals should be finished in about a year and the Federal Government's pest animal strategy was due this year.

"I hate when people think of feral animals as a black and white issue, as in black and white photos of rabbits," he said. "It's a here and now issue that is not going to go away."

THE PESTS THAT ARE DESTROYING AUSTRALIA



FOXES

Population: 7.2 million.
Habitat: Southern two-thirds of Australia.
Economic and environmental impact: $228 million annually. Australia's number 1 predator of native animals and a major agricultural pest.
Control: Successful baiting carried out on 3.5 million ha of conservation land in WA. Other control methods include fencing and shooting.

CATS

Population: 18 million.
Habitat: Throughout Australia.
Economic and environmental impact: $146 million annually. Major threat to native fauna.
Control: Successfully eradicated on some islands. On mainland, barrier fencing with eradication inside fencing.

RABBITS

Population: Unquantified.
Habitat: Throughout Australia except in northernmost areas.
Economic and environmental impact: $113 million annually. Major agricultural and environmental pest.
Control: Myxoma virus and calicivirus have reduced numbers.





PIGS

Population: Up to 23 million.
Habitat: Confined to coastal areas. In WA, they are found along the coastline south of Northampton. Spread aided by the illegal release of pigs for recreational hunting.
Economic and environmental impact: $1.07 million annually. Environmental impact not quantified. Major environmental and agricultural pest.
Control: Mustering and shooting from helicopters, traps, poisoning, and electric fences. Successful control program in Denbarker, on the south coast.

DOGS

Population: Unquantified.
Habitat: Throughout much of mainland Australia.
Economic and environmental impact: $66.3 million annually. Environmental impact not quantified. Pest of agriculture, particularly sheep production, and predator of native species.
Control: Extensive baiting and shooting in WA's rangelands. Efforts have increased recently.

GOATS

Population: 2.6 million in 1996. Numbers thought to double every 8-10 years.
Habitat: Across Australia, except NT.
Economic and environmental impact: $7.7 million annually. Major impact on native vegetation and land degradation.
Control: Mustered for slaughter or culled through helicopter shoots.



CAMELS

Population: More than 600,000.
Habitat: Central Australia and WA.
Economic and environmental impact: $200,000 annually. Damage native vegetation and pastoral infrastructure and cause soil erosion.
Control: Shot, trapped or excluded from high conservation areas by strong fences.

DEER

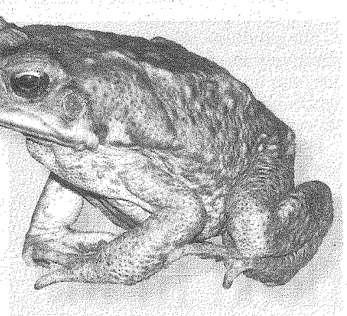
Population: Unquantified.
Habitat: Found throughout Australia. Spread aided by the illegal releases from unviable farms and for hunting.
Economic and environmental impact: Impact not quantified. Can damage native vegetation and agriculture.
Control: Limited measures.

DONKEYS

Population: Unquantified.
Habitat: Inland and northern areas.
Economic and environmental impact: Not quantified. Major pest in the Kimberley and Pilbara due to pastoral degradation.
Control: More than 550,000 donkeys have been culled since shooting and radio tracking started in the Kimberley in 1979.

CATTLE

Population: Unquantified.
Habitat: Pastoral areas of Australia.
Economic and environmental impact: Not quantified. Damage native vegetation
Control: Mustering and shooting.



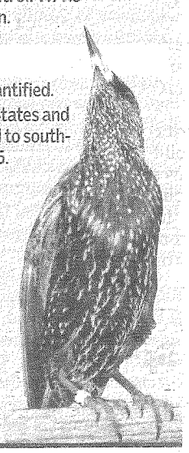
NEW THREATS

CANE TOAD

Population: Unquantified.
Habitat: Queensland, parts of the Northern Territory and NSW and are now entering WA.
Economic and environmental impact: $500,000 annually. Eats small native animals and poisons predators. Household pets also at risk.
Control: Scientists are searching for a biological control. WA is spending $6 million.

STARLINGS

Population: Unquantified.
Habitat: Eastern States and have been confined to south-east WA since 1975.
Economic and environmental impact: Compete with native birds, major agricultural threat and nuisance pest.
Control: WA spending $3.15 million on eradication programs.



SOURCES: COOPERATIVE RESEARCH CENTRE FOR PEST ANIMAL CONTROL, FEDERAL DEPARTMENT OF ENVIRONMENT AND HERITAGE, DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE AND FOOD WA, DEPARTMENT OF ENVIRONMENT AND CONSERVATION WA.

Rider who sprayed dirt on man's body to meet family

SAM RILEY

A 15-year-old trailbike rider who sprayed the body of a dead motorcyclist with dirt when police asked him to divert around the crash scene will have to face the man's family.

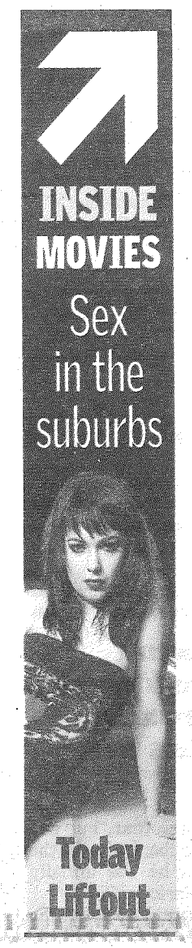
A 25-year-old man died on Sunday after falling off his trailbike in the Gnangara pine plantation. When the boy arrived on a trailbike police told him to divert around the crash site.

Police allege the boy got angry and did a burnout, spraying police and the sheet-covered body with dirt.

Police spokesman Ian Hasleby said friends and family of the dead man were deeply offended.

The youth was arrested. "He was taken into custody for his own protection as associates of the dead man were deeply upset by what he had done," Mr Hasleby said.

He would be charged by summons with hindering police and there were plans to make him meet relatives of the dead man to apologise. "This was a young lair who thought he was more important than anything else that was happening," Mr Hasleby said.





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Feral Animals Article – West Australian October 24th 2006.

There are 12 pests identified in the West Australian article.

They are: _____

_____

_____

Using the article answer the following questions

How are 'gun-happy' West Australians adding to the problem of feral animal populations?

_____

_____

The devastation of feral animals is leaving a _____

_____ worth hundreds of millions of dollars.

How much is the fine for releasing deer into the wild? _____

What are the two new introduced species? _____

_____

As well as major agricultural pests, feral animals cause _____

_____, threaten _____

_____ and are a disease risk.

What animal had the biggest impact in the States agricultural region? _____

What animal had the biggest economical and social impact? _____

What animal had the biggest environmental impact? _____

What two populations had increased in the agricultural region over the past 5 years? _

_____

What population of animals is thought to be doubling every 8-10 years? _____

Name 4 effective control measures that have decreased population numbers of feral animals. _____

_____

_____

Why is more money being spent on the eradication of a new pest, rather then trying to manage the populations of established pests? _____

_____

_____

What is the name of the State's proposed Act to lead to feral animal control? _____

_____

Why do you think many of the feral animal populations are listed as an unquantified amount? _____

_____

What strategies do you think would be more effective in combating the problem of feral animals in Australia? _____

_____

_____

_____

_____